

COACH DEVELOPMENT IN NATIONAL SPORTING ORGANISATIONS: ORGANISATION AND IMPLEMENTATION

Liam Mulcahy¹, A/Prof Helen Brown^{1,2}, Dr Zoe Avner¹, Dr David Broadbent¹ and Dr Will Vickery^{1,2}

¹ Institute for Physical Activity and Nutrition, Deakin University; ² Australian Sports Commission

INTRODUCTION

Coach development is an ongoing and multifaceted process designed to enhance coaches' knowledge, skills, and effectiveness¹. National Sporting Organisations (NSOs) play a central role in this process by providing coach development opportunities². Consequently, understanding how these organisations organise and deliver coach development is critical to identifying effective ways to support coaches' learning and progression³. Despite this importance, research examining coach development practices within Australian sporting organisations remains limited, particularly regarding the organisational factors and decision-making processes that shape their design and delivery⁴. Therefore, this study aimed to explore how coach development is organised and implemented within Australian NSOs and to examine the factors influencing these processes.

METHODS

This study forms part of a PhD thesis, *Exploration of Coach Development Approaches in the Australian Context*. Semi-structured online interviews were conducted with coach development managers from Australian National Sporting Organisations (NSOs) (n = 12) to explore their perspectives on the factors influencing coach development. Interview transcripts were imported into NVivo 15 and analysed using reflexive thematic analysis⁵ to identify patterns of meaning across the dataset.

Following thematic analysis, Bernstein's theory of pedagogic discourse⁶ was applied as an analytical lens to interpret how knowledge was valued, organised, and communicated within NSOs. The framework focuses on how knowledge is generated, recontextualised, and reproduced within educational settings, while also highlighting the power relations and tensions between theory and practice that shape coach development.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

Three related themes were identified from the thematic analysis:

(1) Organisational performance metrics versus pedagogical aims.

NSOs often prioritised coach development activities that generated measurable outcomes, such as course completions and coaching accreditations. From a Bernsteinian perspective, this reflects a performance-driven evaluative discourse in which quantifiable outputs became the primary mechanism for legitimising coach development activity. Consequently, more developmental and relational forms of learning were

often afforded less value, highlighting the influence of managerialism and market-oriented accountability on coach development practices.

(2) Navigating evolving approaches to coach development.

NSOs described expanding coach development beyond traditional formal education through non-formal, online, and hybrid learning opportunities. Bernstein's concept of recontextualisation highlights how these approaches reflected ongoing tensions between operational performance demands and pedagogical aspirations, including the need to accommodate diverse coach needs and preferences. Although framing became weaker through more flexible learning opportunities, NSOs maintained strong control over what knowledge and practices were valued, often marginalising relational and longitudinal learning. The extent to which these approaches could be implemented was also shaped by organisational resources, particularly workforce and financial capacity.

(3) Considering recontextualisation of coach development

Coach development knowledge was continually reshaped as it moved from policy to practice, with stakeholders interpreting and adapting initiatives to their local contexts. Approaches that were scalable and efficient across jurisdictions were typically prioritised by NSOs. However, State Sporting Organisations (SSOs) consistently recontextualised NSO initiatives to meet local needs, particularly within federated governance structures. This suggests that NSOs must recognise the realisation rules operating within SSOs to maintain strong classification of coach development objectives while allowing sufficient flexibility in local implementation.

CONCLUSIONS

The findings suggest that coach development approaches are shaped not only by pedagogical intent, but also by the organisational performance imperatives and governance structures. These findings indicate that improving coach development extends beyond pedagogical considerations and requires attention to the governance structures and performance demands that shape what NSOs are able to prioritise and implement.

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